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Footwear with jointed sole structure for ease of access

Abstract

An article of footwear includes a sole structure that has a front midsole component and a rear midsole component. A hinge connects the front midsole component to the rear midsole component and is disposed in a groove defined between the front and rear midsole components at a lower. The front midsole component and the rear midsole component are pivotable relative to one another at the groove between a use position and an access position, with the groove relatively open in the use position, and the groove relatively closed in the access position.

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Attorney, Agent or Firm: Quinn IP Law

Background/Summary

CROSS-REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATIONS (1) This application claims the benefit of priority to U.S. Provisional Application No. 63/428,370 filed Nov. 28, 2022, which is hereby incorporated by reference in its entirety.

TECHNICAL FIELD

(1) The present disclosure generally relates to an article of footwear, and more specifically to an article of footwear with a jointed sole structure for ease of access.

BACKGROUND

(2) Traditionally, placing footwear on a foot often requires the use of one or both hands to stretch the ankle opening of a footwear upper and hold the rear portion during foot insertion. The fit of the upper is then adjusted following foot insertion, such as by tying laces.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

- (1) The drawings described herein are for illustrative purposes only, are schematic in nature, and are intended to be exemplary rather than to limit the scope of the disclosure.
- (2) FIG. 1 is a medial side view of an article of footwear with a sole structure in a use position.
- (3) FIG. 2 is a lateral side view of the article of footwear of FIG. 1 with the sole structure in the use position.
- (4) FIG. 3 is a lateral side view of the article of footwear of FIG. 1 in an access position.
- (5) FIG. 4 is a lateral side view of the article of footwear of FIG. 1 pivoted further than the access position with a lateral-side stiffening layer and protruding lateral-side tab visible.
- (6) FIG. 5 is a bottom view of the article of footwear of FIG. 1 in the use position.
- (7) FIG. 6 is a fragmentary perspective view of the article of footwear of FIG. 1 in the access position.
- (8) FIG. 7 is a lateral side view of an alternative example of an article of footwear in a use position and showing a footwear upper in phantom.
- (9) FIG. 8 is a medial side view of the sole structure of the article of footwear of FIG. 7.
- (10) FIG. 9 is a bottom view of the sole structure of the article of footwear of FIG. 7.
- (11) FIG. 10 is a top view of the sole structure of the article of footwear of FIG. 7.
- (12) FIG. 11 is a cross-sectional view of the sole structure of the article of footwear of FIG. 7 taken at lines I-I in FIG. 10.
- (13) FIG. 12 is a cross-sectional view of the sole structure of the article of footwear of FIG. 7 taken at lines II-II in FIG. 10.
- (14) FIG. 13 shows the heel footbed and insole of the sole structure of the cross-sectional view of FIG. 12.
- (15) FIG. 14 shows the rear midsole component and outsole of the cross-sectional view of FIG. 12.
- (16) FIG. 15 is a fragmentary side view of the medial side of the heel footbed of the sole structure

of the article of footwear of FIG. 7 showing a medial-side stiffening layer including a medial-side protruding tab.

(17) FIG. 16 is a fragmentary side view of the lateral side of the heel footbed of the sole structure of the article of footwear of FIG. 7 showing a lateral-side stiffening layer including a lateral-side protruding tab.

(18) FIG. 17 is a cross-sectional view of the sole structure of the article of footwear of FIG. 7 taken at lines III-III in FIG. 10.

(19) FIG. 18 is a cross-sectional view of the sole structure of the article of footwear of FIG. 7 taken at lines IV-IV in FIG. 10.

(20) FIG. 19 is a cross-sectional view of the sole structure of the article of footwear of FIG. 7 taken at lines V-V in FIG. 10.

(21) FIG. 20 is a top view of an external stiffening layer for the heel footbed of the front midsole component shown in FIG. 21.

(22) FIG. 21 is a bottom perspective and fragmentary view of a heel footbed of a front midsole component with the external stiffening layer of FIG. 20.

(23) FIG. 22 is a top perspective view of a peripheral support for the rear midsole component of FIG. 23.

(24) FIG. 23 is a top perspective view of the peripheral support of FIG. 22 extending along the side walls at the inner surface of a rear midsole component and showing a transversely-extending resilient band.

(25) FIG. 24 is a cross-sectional view of the heel footbed and external stiffening layer of FIG. 21 taken at a cross-section indicated by lines VI-VI in FIG. 25 with the side protrusions disposed in recesses of the rear midsole component below the peripheral support of FIG. 23.

(26) FIG. 25 is a cross-sectional view of an article of footwear taken along a longitudinal midline of the article of footwear and including a divided footwear upper shown in phantom and a sole structure including the front midsole component with the heel footbed and external stiffening layer of FIG. 21 and the rear midsole component and peripheral support of FIG. 23.

DESCRIPTION

(27) An article of footwear disclosed herein may enable hands-free placement of the article of footwear on a foot by providing a sole structure with separate front and rear midsole components that define a groove at a lower side of the sole structure with a hinge disposed in the groove and connecting the midsole components. The hinge enables the sole structure to pivot (e.g., articulate) at the groove between a first orientation, referred to as a use position in which the groove is relatively open, and a second orientation, referred to as an access position in which the groove is relatively closed.

(28) In some examples, separate front and rear upper portions may be secured to the front and rear midsole components. At least parts of the front and rear upper portions may be further apart from one another in the access position than in the use position, allowing easier foot entry into the front upper portion, and with the rear upper portion then automatically closing around the foot as the footwear returns to the use position under a load of the foot.

(29) In some implementations, the article of footwear may be characterized by the absence of a biasing member extending between and connecting the front midsole component and the rear midsole component, or extending between and connecting the front upper portion and the rear upper portion, or extending between and connecting the front midsole component and the rear upper portion, and configured to maintain the sole structure in the access position and/or in the use position. Instead, for example, the outsole may be characterized by at least a predetermined coefficient of friction (e.g., a static coefficient of friction and/or a sliding coefficient of friction of at least a predetermined magnitude) to maintain the sole structure in the access position until loaded by a foot to move to the use position. For example, the material and configuration of the

outsole alone may provide at least the predetermined coefficient of friction to maintain the sole structure in the access position until loaded by a foot to move to the use position without any of an elastic band(s), biasing plate(s), or other component(s) included primarily to provide a biasing force that urges the sole structure toward the access position and/or the use position.

(30) In addition, in some examples, the front midsole component may include a heel footbed that extends over the groove and overlays the rear midsole component in the use position. The article of footwear may include a divided footwear upper with a front upper portion secured to the front midsole component and a separate rear upper portion secured to the rear midsole component. The rear upper portion may include at least a portion of a heel collar, and the heel collar may be configured to support the heel footbed in the access position and resiliently deform to permit the heel footbed to move past the heel collar to the use position.

(31) In an example, a resilient band may be suspended over and extend transversely across a portion of the inner surface of the rear midsole component (e.g., the top surface, also referred to as the foot support surface). For example, the resilient band may be secured to the inner surface at the medial and lateral side walls of the rear midsole component. In the access position, the resilient band may be spaced apart from portion of the inner surface of the rear midsole component and a heel footbed may rest on the resilient band. In the use position, the resilient band may resiliently stretch under load to allow the heel footbed to rest on the inner surface of the rear midsole component.

(32) In an aspect, a side of the heel footbed and an inner surface of the rear midsole component may include complementary interlocking features that secure the heel footbed in the use position. In some examples, a tab may protrude at a side periphery of the heel footbed, and the rear midsole component may at least partially define a recess at an inner surface of the rear midsole component in which the tab is disposed to secure the heel footbed in the use position until a removal force is applied to the sole structure as discussed herein. The medial side of the heel footbed, the lateral side of the heel footbed, or both, may include such a tab. In other examples, the side periphery of the heel footbed may include a recess and the rear midsole component may include a tab protruding at the inner surface of the rear midsole component that is disposed in the recess of the heel footbed to secure the heel footbed in the use position until a removal force is applied to the sole structure as discussed herein.

(33) In an example, the sole structure may comprise a stiffening layer secured to the side periphery of the heel footbed and the medial-side tab and the lateral-side tab may be integral with the stiffening layer.

(34) In another example, a peripheral support may be secured to the rear midsole component, such as at the inner side walls at the inner surface of the rear midsole component and may have an edge disposed adjacent to the recess in the rear midsole component. The wall support may be stiffer than the rear midsole component and the tab may be disposed in the recess under the edge of the wall support when the sole structure is in the use position to secure the heel footbed in the use position. In this manner, the more rigid wall support helps to maintain the tab in the recess.

(35) The hands-free operation of the article of footwear may be made possible by these and/or other aspects described herein.

(36) The above features and advantages and other features and advantages of the present teachings are readily apparent from the following detailed description of the modes for carrying out the present teachings when taken in connection with the accompanying drawings. It should be understood that even though embodiments may be separately described in the following Figures, single features thereof may be combined in additional embodiments.

(37) Referring to the drawings, wherein like reference numbers refer to like components throughout the views, FIG. 1 shows an example of an article of footwear **10** (also referred to herein simply as footwear **10**) that includes a sole structure **12** and a footwear upper **14** (also referred to herein as an upper). As discussed herein, these and other features of the article of footwear **10** enable an access

position of the article of footwear **10** (such as shown in FIG. **3**) that particularly affords easy, hands-free foot entry into the article of footwear **10**. Additionally, the article of footwear **10** adopts a use position (such as shown in FIG. **1**) after foot entry, particularly also in a hands-free manner. The article of footwear **10** herein is depicted as a leisure shoe or an athletic shoe, but the present teachings are not limited to such, and also encompass dress shoes, work shoes, sandals, slippers, boots, or any other category of footwear.

(38) The article of footwear **10** has three general regions: a forefoot region **16**, a midfoot region **18**, and a heel region **20**, which are also the forefoot region, the midfoot region, and the heel region, respectively, of the sole structure **12** and the footwear upper **14**. The footwear **10** also includes a medial side **22** and a lateral side **24** (best shown in FIG. **2**) opposite from the medial side **22**.

(39) The forefoot region **16** generally includes portions of the article of footwear **10** corresponding with the toes and the joints connecting the metatarsals with the phalanges of a wearer's foot. The midfoot region **18** generally includes portions of the article of footwear **10** corresponding with the arch area of the foot, and the heel region **20** corresponds with rear portions of the foot, including the calcaneus bone. The medial side **22** and the lateral side **24** extend through each of forefoot region **16**, the midfoot region **18**, and the heel region **20** and correspond with opposite sides of the article of footwear **10**. The forefoot region **16**, the midfoot region **18**, the heel region **20**, the medial side **22**, and the lateral side **24** are not intended to demarcate precise areas of footwear **10** but are instead intended to represent general areas of footwear **10** to aid in the following discussion.

(40) The sole structure **12** includes a midsole **28** that has a front midsole component **28A** and a separate rear midsole component **28B**. The rear midsole component **28B** is separate and divided from the front midsole component **28A**. Stated differently, the front midsole component **28A** particularly is not integrally formed with, is not unitary with, and/or is not directly attached to the rear midsole component **28B**. The front midsole component **28A** and the rear midsole component **28B** together define a groove **30** at a lower side **32** of the sole structure **12** between the front midsole component **28A** and the rear midsole component **28B**.

(41) The footwear upper **14** may be a divided footwear upper having a front upper portion **50A** and a rear upper portion **50B**. The divided footwear upper **14** is secured to the sole structure **12** to define a foot-receiving cavity **52**. More particularly, the front upper portion **50A** is secured to the front midsole component **28A**, and the separate rear upper portion **50B** is secured to the rear midsole component **28B**. The footwear upper **14** is referred to as divided because the front upper portion **50A** and the rear upper portion **50B** are separate, discrete upper components that are not physically directly connected to one another.

(42) A hinge **34** is disposed in the groove **30** and connects the front midsole component **28A** to the rear midsole component **28B**. The front midsole component **28A** and the rear midsole component **28B** are pivotable relative to one another at the groove **30** between a use position (shown in FIGS. **1** and **2**) and an access position (shown in FIGS. **3** and **6**). The groove **30** is relatively open in the use position and relatively closed in the access position.

(43) Referring to FIG. **2**, the front midsole component **28A** includes a first wall **36** defining a front of the groove **30**. The rear midsole component **28B** includes a second wall **38** defining a rear of the groove **30**. The hinge **34** has a first wall **34A** that lines the first wall **36**. The hinge **34** has a second wall **34B** integral with the first wall **34A**. The first wall **34A** and the second wall **34B** define a peak **40** therebetween. The second wall **34B** of the hinge **34** lines the second wall **38** of the rear midsole component **28B**. The hinge **34** flexes at the peak **40** when the sole structure **12** moves between the use position and the access position.

(44) Confronting surfaces of the hinge **34** at the groove **30** (e.g., exposed surfaces or outer surfaces of the first wall **34A** and the second wall **34B** of the hinge **34**) are closer to one another in the access position (see FIG. **3**) than in the use position (see FIG. **2**) so that the groove **30** is relatively open in the use position in comparison to the access position, and the groove **30** is relatively closed in the access position in comparison to the use position. Specifically, as shown in FIG. **1**, the

groove **30** is relatively open and/or the front upper portion **50A** and the rear upper portion **50B** are adjacent to one another in the use position. As shown in FIG. **3**, the groove **30** is relatively closed and at least parts of the front upper portion **50A** and the rear upper portion **50B** are spaced further apart from one another in the access position than in the use position, widening the ankle opening **65** in comparison to the use position to ease foot entry.

(45) The sole structure **12** further includes an outsole **42**. In the example shown, the outsole **42** includes three discrete components: a front outsole component **42A**, a rear outsole component **42B**, and a toe region outsole component **42C**, as best shown in FIG. **5**. The front outsole component **42A** and the toe region outsole component **42C** are secured to the bottom surface **44** of the front midsole component **28A** (see FIG. **2**). The toe region outsole component **42C** is discrete and separate from the front outsole component **42A**. The front midsole component **28A** spans a gap **46** (see FIG. **5**) between the toe region outsole component **42C** and the front outsole component **42A** and may extend at least partially downward into the gap **46** between the toe region outsole component **42C** and the front outsole component **42A**. The rear outsole component **42B** is secured to a bottom surface **48** of the rear midsole component **28B** and is discrete and separate from the front midsole component **28A**. The front outsole component **42A** is entirely forward of the groove **30** and the rear outsole component **42B** is entirely rearward of the groove **30**.

(46) The hinge **34** includes a forward leg **34C** integral with the first wall **34A** and extending forward from the first wall **34A** under the front midsole component **28A**. The hinge **34** further includes a rear leg **34D** integral with the second wall **34B** and extending rearward from the second wall **34B** under the rear midsole component **28B**. The front outsole component **42A** is secured to the bottom surface of the forward leg **34C** of the hinge **34**, and the rear outsole component **42B** is secured to the bottom surface of the rear leg **34D** of the hinge **34**. For example, the outsole components **42A**, **42B**, and **42C** may be secured to the respective front and rear midsole components **28A**, **28B** and the outsole components **42A**, **42B** to the respective forward and rear legs **34C**, **34D** with adhesive, by heat bonding, or otherwise.

(47) In FIG. **1**, the groove **30** particularly is configured as substantially having a triangular shape in a cross-section taken along a longitudinal length of the article of footwear **10**. In other examples, the groove **30** may be more semi-circular, square, or rectangular in cross-section. The groove **30** may have any cross-sectional shape that allows the two midsole components **28A**, **28B** to pivot relative to one another at the groove **30**. The peak **40** of the hinge **34** or the top of the groove **30** at a cross-section through the groove **30** particularly is configured to permit flexing of the material for opening and closing of the groove **30** while minimizing or reducing stress concentrations or fatigue. For example, if a top of the groove **30** and a peak **40** of the hinge **34** particularly extends from the lateral side **24** to the medial side **22** of the sole structure **12**, then internal forces resulting from the flexing (such as forces on the hinge **34**) are spread across the width of the sole structure **12**, reducing stress concentrations. Additionally, if the top of the groove **30** and the peak **40** of the hinge **34** particularly have a relatively rounded rather than a relatively pointed shape (e.g., do not have a pointed apex), internal forces are spread over a greater area of the material, reducing stress concentrations in comparison to a pointed groove.

(48) The front midsole component **28A** and the rear midsole component **28B** may comprise, for example, an elastomeric foam such as a polyurethane or ethylvinylacetate foam to attenuate ground reaction forces (i.e., provide cushioning) when compressed between the foot and the ground during walking, running, or other ambulatory activities. Either or both of the front midsole component **28A** and the rear midsole component **28B** may incorporate fluid-filled chambers, plates, moderators, or other elements that further attenuate forces, enhance stability, or influence the motions of the foot. For example, the heel footbed **43** of the front midsole component **28A** discussed herein may include a first plate **198** and a second plate **199** as discussed with respect to the article of footwear **110**.

(49) In the example shown, the foam of the midsole components **28A**, **28B** may include a foamed

polymeric material and may be at least partially a polyurethane (PU) foam, a polyurethane ethylene-vinyl acetate (EVA) foam, and may include heat-expanded and molded EVA foam pellets. (50) The foamed polymeric material includes one or more polymers. The one or more polymers may include an elastomer, including a thermoplastic elastomer (TPE). The one or more polymers may include aliphatic polymers, aromatic polymers, or mixture of both. In one example, the one or more polymers may include homopolymers, copolymers (including terpolymers), or mixtures of both. The copolymers may be random copolymers, block copolymers, alternating copolymers, periodic copolymers, or graft copolymers, for instance. The one or more polymers may include olefinic homopolymers or copolymers or a mixture of olefinic homopolymers and copolymers. Examples of olefinic polymers include polyethylene (PE) and polypropylene (PP). For example, the PE may be a PE homopolymer such as a low density PE or a high density PE, a low molecular weight PE or an ultra-high molecular weight PE, a linear PE or a branched chain PE, etc. The PE may be an ethylene copolymer such as, for example, an ethylene-vinyl acetate (EVA) copolymer, an ethylene-vinyl alcohol (EVOH) copolymer, an ethylene-ethyl acrylate copolymer, an ethylene-unsaturated mono-fatty acid copolymer, etc. The one or more polymers may include a polyacrylate such as a polyacrylic acid, an ester of a polyacrylic acid, a polyacrylonitrile, a polyacrylic acetate, a polymethyl acrylate, a polyethyl acrylate, a polybutyl acrylate, a polymethyl methacrylate, a polyvinyl acetate, etc., including derivatives thereof, copolymers thereof, and any mixture thereof, in one example. The one or more polymers may include an ionomeric polymer. The ionomeric polymer may be a polycarboxylic acid or a derivative of a polycarboxylic acid, for instance. The ionomeric polymer may be a sodium salt, a magnesium salt, a potassium salt, or a salt of another metallic ion. The ionomeric polymer may be a fatty acid modified ionomeric polymer. Examples of ionomeric polymers include polystyrene sulfonate, and ethylene-methacrylic acid copolymers. The one or more polymers may include a polycarbonate. The one or more polymers may include a fluoropolymer. The one or more polymers may include a polysiloxane. The one or more polymers may include a vinyl polymer such as polyvinyl chloride (PVC), polyvinyl acetate, polyvinyl alcohol, etc. The one or more polymers may include a polystyrene. The polystyrene may be a styrene copolymer such as, for example, an acrylonitrile butadiene styrene (ABS), a styrene acrylonitrile (SAN), a styrene ethylene butylene styrene (SEBS), a styrene ethylene propylene styrene (SEPS), a styrene butadiene styrene (SBS), etc. The one or more polymers may include a polyamide (PA). The PA may be a PA **6**, PA **66**, PA **11**, or a copolymer thereof. The polyester may be an aliphatic polyester homopolymer or copolymer such as polyglycolic acid, polylactic acid, polycaprolactone, polyhydroxybutyrate, and the like. The polyester may be a semi-aromatic copolymer such as polyethylene terephthalate (PET) or polybutylene terephthalate (PBT). The one or more polymers may include a polyether such as a polyethylene glycol or polypropylene glycol, including copolymers thereof. The one or more polymers may include a polyurethane, including an aromatic polyurethane derived from an aromatic isocyanate such as diphenylmethane diisocyanate (MDI) or toluene diisocyanate (TDI), or an aliphatic polyurethane derived from an aliphatic isocyanate such as hexamethylene diisocyanate (HDI) or isophone diisocyanate (IPDI), or a mixture of both an aromatic polyurethane and an aliphatic polyurethane.

(51) The foamed polymeric material may be a chemically foamed polymeric material, which is foamed using a chemical blowing agent that forms a gas when heated. For example, the chemical blowing agent can be an azo compound such as azodicarbonamide, sodium bicarbonate, or an isocyanate. Alternatively, or additionally, the foamed polymeric material may be a physically foamed polymeric material, which is foamed using a physical blowing agent which changes phase from a liquid or a supercritical fluid to a gas due to changes in temperature and/or pressure.

(52) Optionally, in addition to the one or more polymers, the polymeric material may further include one or more fillers such as glass fiber, powdered glass, modified or natural silica, calcium carbonate, mica, paper, wood chips, modified or natural clays, modified or unmodified synthetic clays, talc, etc. Similarly, the polymeric material optionally may further include one or more

colorants, such as pigments or dyes. Other optional components of the polymeric material include processing aids, ultra-violet light absorbers, and the like.

(53) The foamed polymeric material may be a crosslinked foamed polymeric material, i.e., a foamed material in which covalent crosslinking bonds exist between at least a portion of the one or more polymers. A crosslinked foamed polymeric material can be formed by including a crosslinking agent in the polymeric material used to form the foam. The crosslinking agent can be a peroxide-based crosslinking agent such as dicumyl peroxide. Alternatively, the foamed polymeric material can be an uncrosslinked foamed polymeric material which has thermoplastic properties. The foamed polymeric material may be an elastomeric foamed material.

(54) The front midsole component **28A** extends in the forefoot region **16** and the midfoot region **18**, and/or particularly includes a heel footbed **43** (see, e.g., FIGS. **3**, **4**, and **6**) that extends in the heel region **20**. Accordingly, the front midsole component **28A** particularly is a full-length midsole component. In other examples, there may be no heel footbed **43**, or there may be a footbed portion extending rearward over the groove **30** that does not extend fully to the heel region **20**. The heel footbed **43** extends over the groove **30** and overlays the rear midsole component **28B** in the use position and is spaced apart from the rear midsole component **28B** in the access position. The heel footbed **43** overlays and contacts a portion **45** of the inner surface **72** of the rear midsole component **28B** in the use position, inward of the rear upper portion **50B**, as shown in phantom in FIG. **2** and discussed herein with respect to corresponding components of the article of footwear **110**. The portion **45** is also referred to as the top surface and/or the foot-facing surface and/or foot support surface and/or top-facing surface of the rear midsole component **28B**.

(55) As shown in FIG. **6**, the heel footbed **43** extends the full width of the foot-receiving cavity **52** between the medial and lateral sides of the rear upper portion **50B** discussed herein. In other examples, the heel footbed **43** need not extend the full width.

(56) The heel footbed **43** particularly is an integral portion of the front midsole component **28A**. Stated differently, the front midsole component **28A**, including the heel footbed **43**, may be a one-piece component, e.g., formed by injection molding or otherwise. In contrast, the rear midsole component **28B** particularly is not a full-length midsole component, as it extends in the heel region **20**, but does not extend in the forefoot region **16**, and/or extends only slightly, if at all, in the midfoot region **18**. The rear midsole component **28B** particularly extends mainly rearward of the groove **30** and mainly in the heel region **20**.

(57) The article of footwear **10** is characterized by an absence of a biasing member configured to maintain the sole structure **12** in one of the use position or the access position (e.g., in a bi-stable arrangement). For example, the footwear upper **14** and the sole structure **12** are characterized by an absence of (e.g., do not include) a biasing member extending between the front upper portion **50A** and the rear upper portion **50B**, or between the front midsole component **28A** and the rear midsole component **28B**, or between the front upper portion **50A** and the rear midsole component **28B**, or between the rear upper portion **50B** and the front midsole component **28A**, etc. Accordingly, no bands, straps, biasing plates, etc. are added to the article of footwear **10** to bias the article of footwear **10** to the use position and/or the access position. Instead, the outsole **42** is characterized by at least a predetermined coefficient of friction (e.g., a predetermined coefficient of static friction and/or a predetermined coefficient of sliding friction) to maintain the sole structure **12** in the access position. Stated differently, the outsole **42** is of a material and a configuration such that contact of the outsole **42** with the ground surface GS when in the access position of FIG. **3** provides sufficient forces resisting relative movement of the outsole components **42A**, **42B**, and/or **42C**, such as sliding of the sole structure **12** on the ground surface GS and preventing the article of footwear **10** from moving to the use position without the loading of an entering foot. Alternatively or in addition, a resilient band such as the resilient band **302** described with respect to FIGS. **23** and **25** may be used to help maintain the article of footwear **10** in the access position.

(58) As shown in FIG. **3**, a portion of the rear outsole component **42B** and a portion of the front

outsole component **42A** and/or the toe region outsole component **42C** rest on the ground surface **GS** in the access position. By selecting the materials of the outsole **42** to provide at least the predetermined coefficient of friction (e.g., a predetermined coefficient of static friction and/or a predetermined coefficient of sliding friction) on various selected materials of the ground surface **GS**, such as typical flooring surfaces, concrete, etc., according to ASTM standardized test(s), no biasing member is needed to maintain the article of footwear in the access position.

(59) In an example, the outsole **42** may be formed from materials that may generally include natural or synthetic rubber or other suitably durable materials. The material or materials for the outsole **42** may be selected to provide a desirable combination of durability, flexibility, and at least the predetermined coefficient of friction discussed herein. Synthetic rubbers that may be used include polybutadiene rubber, ethylene propylene rubber (EPR), styrene isoprene styrene (SIS) copolymer rubber, and styrene butadiene rubber.

(60) Referring to FIG. 5, the outsole components **42A**, **42B**, and **42C** each include a plurality of spaced tread elements **58** only some of which are indicated reference numbers in FIG. 5. Alternatively, none of or only one or two of the outsole components **42A**, **42B**, and **42C** may include such tread elements **58**. The tread elements **58** extend from a medial side edge **59A** to a lateral side edge **59B** of the sole structure **12** in each of the forefoot region **16**, the midfoot region **18**, and the heel region **20**. The tread elements **58** extend downward and define a portion of the ground engaging surface **61** of the sole structure **12**. The tread elements **58** ensure sufficient contact with the ground surface **GS** even in the case of an uneven ground surface. Additionally, the tread elements **58** have sufficient compliance to increase friction relative to the ground surface **GS** in comparison to a ground engaging surface without the tread elements **58**.

(61) Optionally, interference between the rear upper portion **50B** and the heel footbed **43** further enhances the ability to maintain the article of footwear **10** in the access position in the absence of loading of an entering foot. For example, in the access position of FIG. 6, the rear upper portion **50B** is shown including a heel collar **60**. The heel collar **60** of the rear upper portion **50B** along with a medial-side front collar portion **62A** and a lateral-side front collar portion **62B** of the front upper portion **50A** define an ankle opening **65** that is wider in the access position (see FIG. 3) than in the use position (see FIG. 2). A medial side portion **60A** of the heel collar **60** and a lateral side portion **60B** of the heel collar **60** are spaced sufficiently close to one another and include sufficient compliant cushioning that the medial and lateral side portions **60A**, **60B** of the heel collar **60** support the heel footbed **43** in the access position (in the absence of loading by an entering foot) and resiliently deform to permit the heel footbed **43** to move past the heel collar **60** to the use position under loading of an entering foot.

(62) The rear upper portion **50B** and the front upper portion **50A** may include any one or more of several different materials. For example, the rear upper portion **50B** and the front upper portion **50A** may include leather, textiles, polymers, cotton, foam, composites, etc., or combinations of these. The rear upper portion **50B** and the front upper portion **50A** may be a polymeric material capable of providing elasticity, and may be of a braided construction, a knitted (e.g., warp-knitted) construction, or a woven construction.

(63) FIG. 4 shows the article of footwear with the sole structure **12** articulated even further than the access position of FIG. 3 (e.g., the groove **30** is further closed than in FIG. 3) exposing more of the heel footbed **43** than in the access position of FIG. 3. For example, the walls **34A**, **34B** of the hinge **34** will eventually touch to provide a stop (e.g., the groove **30** completely closes to prevent further rotation or pivotal movement toward one another), but the exterior surfaces of the first and second walls **34A**, **34B** in the groove **30** need not necessarily touch in the access position of FIG. 3.

(64) To help maintain the article of footwear **10** in the use position, FIG. 4 shows that the sole structure **12** includes a lateral-side tab **64** protruding at a lateral-side periphery **66** of the heel footbed **43**. In the example shown, the sole structure **12** includes a lateral-side stiffening layer **68** secured at the lateral-side periphery **66** of the heel footbed **43**, and the lateral-side tab **64** is an

integral portion of the lateral-side stiffening layer **68**. The lateral-side stiffening layer **68** and the integral lateral-side tab **64** are stiffer than the heel footbed **43**. Although not shown, the heel footbed **43** may include a like medial-side stiffening layer secured at the medial side periphery **69** (see FIG. **6**) of the heel footbed **43** and a medial-side tab as an integral portion of the medial-side stiffening layer, as shown with respect to the article of footwear **110** in FIG. **12**. In FIGS. **3** and **6**, the lateral-side stiffening layer **68** and the integral lateral-side tab **64** are covered by the rear upper portion **50B** in the access position.

(65) The lateral-side stiffening layer **68** may be secured to the body **70** of the heel footbed **43** such as with adhesive, or may be coated on the body **70**, or otherwise applied to define a portion of the lateral-side periphery **66** of the heel footbed **43**. In one example, the lateral-side stiffening layer **68** is molded separately from the body **70** and is then adhered to the body **70**. In another example, foam used to form the body **70** may be processed such as by temperature-controlled curing so that the lateral-side stiffening layer **68** is an integral external skin of the body **70** that is more dense than a remaining internal portion of the body **70** that it covers.

(66) The body **70** may be relatively less hard than the lateral-side stiffening layer **68** and the integral lateral-side tab **64**. For example, the body **70** may have a first hardness and the lateral-side stiffening layer **68** and the integral lateral-side tab **64** may have a second hardness greater than the first hardness. For example, the body **70** may be elastomeric foam, as discussed, and the lateral-side stiffening layer **68** and the integral lateral-side tab **64** may be a semi-rigid or rigid plastic (such as a thermoplastic), a composite, nylon, a polyether block amide such as PEBA[®] available from Arkema, Inc. in King of Prussia, Pennsylvania USA, a fiberglass reinforced polyamide, a rigid thermoplastic polyurethane (with or without glass fiber).

(67) Because the protruding lateral-side tab **64** is of the harder material of the lateral-side stiffening layer **68**, the lateral-side tab **64** moves past softer, compressible portions of the rear upper portion **50B** and the rear midsole component **28B** by compressing such portions when under loading of an entering foot and then interlocks with the rear midsole component **28B** in the use position. Specifically, the rear midsole component **28B** includes an inner surface **72** (indicated in phantom in FIG. **2**) with a lateral-side recess in a lateral side of the inner surface, as shown in greater detail with respect to the like inner surface **72** of the rear midsole component **128B** of the article of footwear **110** in FIG. **12**. The lateral-side tab **64** is disposed in the lateral-side recess when the sole structure **12** moves to the use position to secure the heel footbed **43** in the use position. More specifically, the lateral-side tab **64** in the lateral-side recess and/or a similar medial side tab in a medial side recess interlocks the heel footbed **43** to the rear midsole component **28B** to help maintain the article of footwear **10** in the use position.

(68) To remove the article of footwear **10** in a hands-free manner, the wearer's opposite foot may be placed on an external ledge **76** of the rear midsole component **28B**. The external ledge **76** may have a reinforcing cover **78** that is a relatively hard plastic, similar to the material of the lateral-side tab **64**. By depressing the external ledge **76** with the wearer's opposite foot pushing down on the cover **78**, the rear midsole component **28B** is urged to pivot downward and rearward with respect to the use position of FIG. **1**, urging the sole structure **12** to articulate to the access position, moving the groove **30** to the relatively closed position, and providing enough force to move the lateral-side tab **64** and any corresponding medial side tab out of the lateral-side recess and any corresponding medial side recess, to release the heel footbed **43**, which moves to the access position of FIG. **3** as the front midsole component **28A** pivots about the groove **30** relative to the rear midsole component **28B**. The frictional forces of the outsole **42** on the ground surface GS are overcome to allow such articulation.

(69) The rear midsole component **28B** may also include a forward-projecting clip (like clip **182** discussed with respect to the article of footwear **110**) that overlays the rear extent of the heel footbed **43** in the use position to further help maintain the heel footbed **43** in the use position. The forward-projecting clip flexibly interfaces with the rear extent of the heel footbed **43** when the sole

structure **12** moves from the use position to the access position. The clip may also be referred to as a lip.

(70) FIGS. 7-8 show an article of footwear **110** alike in all aspects to the article of footwear **10** except that the shape of a rear midsole component **128B** of the article of footwear **110** is more tapered at the rear than rear midsole component **28B** and includes a bottom recess **129** (see FIG. 9), a reinforcing cover **178** extends further around the medial and lateral sides **22**, **24** in the heel region **20** on the external ledge **176** than does the reinforcing cover **78** of the article of footwear **10** (as best shown in FIG. 10), and the outsole components **142A**, **142B**, **142C** corresponding with outsole components **42A**, **42B**, and **42C**, respectively, have a slightly differently layout of tread elements **158**, as shown in FIG. 9. The rear outsole component **142B** includes an aperture **144** at the bottom recess **129**. The front outsole component **142A** underlies the forward leg **34C** of the hinge **34** and the rear outsole component **142B** underlies the rear leg **34D**.

(71) In the cross-sectional view of the hinge **34** shown in FIG. 11, it is apparent that the hinge **34** includes a forward ridge **35A** at the intersection of the first wall **34A** and the forward leg **34C**, and a rear ridge **35B** at the intersection of the second wall **34B** and the rear leg **34D**. The ridges **35A**, **35B** extend downward and serve as alignment features for securing the front and rear outsole components **142A**, **142B** to the front and rear legs **34C**, **34D**. The front outsole component **142A** is abutted against the front ridge **35A** and the rear outsole component **142B** is abutted against the rear ridge **35B** to properly align the outsole components **142A**, **142B** with the hinge **34**.

(72) Like the article of footwear **10**, the article of footwear **110** is also characterized by an absence of a biasing member configured to maintain the sole structure **112** in one of the use position or the access position (e.g., in a bi-stable arrangement). For example, the footwear upper **14** and the sole structure **112** are characterized by an absence of a biasing member extending between the front upper portion **50A** and the rear upper portion **50B**, or between the front midsole component **128A** and the rear midsole component **128B**, or between the front upper portion **50A** and the rear midsole component **128B**, or between the rear upper portion **50B** and the front midsole component **128A**. Accordingly, no bands, straps, biasing plates, etc. are included to bias the article of footwear **110** to the use position and/or the access position. Instead, the outsole **142** is characterized by at least a predetermined coefficient of friction (e.g., of static friction or of sliding friction) to maintain the sole structure **112** in the access position. Stated differently, the outsole **142** is of a material and a configuration such that contact of the outsole **142** with the ground surface GS when in the access position like that of the article of footwear **10** in FIG. 3 provides sufficient forces to resist relative movement of the outsole components **142A**, **142B**, and/or **142C** such as sliding of the sole structure **112** on the ground surface GS and preventing the article of footwear **110** from moving to the use position without the loading of an entering foot.

(73) In the access position, the outsole **142** rests on a portion of the rear outsole component **142B** and on a portion of the front outsole component **142A** and/or the toe region outsole component **142C**. By selecting the materials of the outsole **142** to provide at least a predetermined coefficient of friction (e.g., of static friction or of sliding friction) on various selected materials of the ground surface GS, such as typical flooring surfaces, concrete, etc., according to ASTM standardized test(s), no biasing member is needed to maintain the article of footwear **110** in the access position.

(74) In an example, the outsole **142** may be formed from materials that may generally include natural or synthetic rubber or other suitably durable materials. The material or materials for the outsole **142** may be selected to provide a desirable combination of durability, flexibility, and at least the predetermined coefficient of friction discussed herein. Synthetic rubbers that may be used include polybutadiene rubber, ethylene propylene rubber (EPR), styrene isoprene styrene (SIS) copolymer rubber, and styrene butadiene rubber.

(75) Referring again to FIG. 9, the outsole components **142A**, **142B**, **142C** each include a plurality of spaced tread elements **158** only some of which are indicated reference numbers in FIG. 9. The tread elements **158** extend from a medial side edge **159A** to a lateral side edge **159B** of the sole

structure **112** in each of the forefoot region **16**, the midfoot region **18**, and the heel region **20**. The tread elements **158** extend downward and define a portion of the ground engaging surface **161** of the sole structure **112**. The tread elements **158** ensure sufficient contact with the ground surface GS of FIG. **8** even in the case of an uneven ground surface. Additionally, the tread elements **158** have sufficient compliance to increase friction relative to a smoother ground-engaging surface that would occur in the absence of tread elements **158**.

(76) Similar to the sole structure **12** of the article of footwear **10**, the sole structure **112** of the article of footwear **110** includes a midsole **128** that has a front midsole component **128A** and a separate rear midsole component **128B**. The rear midsole component **128B** is separate and divided from the front midsole component **128A**. Stated differently, the front midsole component **128A** particularly is not integrally formed with, is not unitary with, and/or is not directly attached to the rear midsole component **128B**. The front midsole component **28A** and the rear midsole component **28B** together define a groove **30** at a lower side **32** of the sole structure **112** between the front midsole component **128A** and the rear midsole component **128B**. The hinge **34** is disposed in the groove **30**, as described with respect to the article of footwear **10**.

(77) The article of footwear **110** includes the divided footwear upper **14** having a front upper portion **50A** and a rear upper portion **50B** as described with respect to the article of footwear **10**, with the front upper portion **50A** secured to the front midsole component **128A**, and the separate rear upper portion **50B** secured to the rear midsole component **128B**.

(78) In FIG. **11**, the heel footbed **43** is shown extending over the groove **30**, overlaying the rear midsole component **128B**, and resting on the portion **45** of the inner surface **72** of the rear midsole component **128B** in the use position. A clip **182** projects forward from the inner surface **72** of the rear midsole component **128B** and overlays a rear extent **184** of the heel footbed **43** when the sole structure **112** is in the use position, as is evident in FIGS. **10** and **11**. The clip **182** flexibly interfaces with the rear extent **184** of the heel footbed **43** when the sole structure **112** moves from the access position (a position like that of FIG. **3**) to the use position of FIG. **11** and from the use position to the access position.

(79) In FIG. **11**, the clip **182** is an integral portion of the cover **178**, at least a portion of which is positioned rearward of the clip **182** along the external ledge **176**. As shown in FIG. **11**, the integral cover **178** and the integral clip **182** step downward in a forward direction from the foot contact surface **192** of the cover **178** on which the wearer's opposite foot contacts to force the sole structure **112** to the access position. At least partly because the clip **182** is integral with the cover **178**, depressing the external ledge **176** and the cover **178** thereon with the opposite foot moves the clip **182** away from the rear extent **184** of the heel footbed **43**, allowing the heel footbed **43** to move upward relative to the clip **182** as the sole structure **112** articulates to the access position.

(80) Like the article of footwear **10**, interference between the heel collar **60** of the rear upper portion **50B** and the heel footbed **43** further enhances the ability to maintain the article of footwear **110** in the access position in the absence of loading of an entering foot.

(81) FIG. **11** shows an insole **190** overlying the front midsole component **128A**, including overlying the heel footbed **43**. Additionally, the front midsole component **128A** is shown with an upward-facing recess **194** in which is housed a fluid-filled bladder **196** to provide cushioning in the metatarsal portion of the forefoot region **16**.

(82) The sole structure **112** includes a first plate **198** disposed on or in the heel footbed **43** and extending over the groove **30** in the use position, and a second plate **199** disposed on or in the heel footbed **43** as shown in FIG. **11**. The second plate **199** is disposed nearer to a bottom surface **200** of the heel footbed **43** than is the first plate **198**, and the first plate **198** is disposed nearer to a top surface **202** of the heel footbed **43** than is the second plate **199**. In the specific example shown, the first plate **198** is disposed at the top surface **202** of the heel footbed **43** and the second plate **199** is disposed at the bottom surface **200** of the heel footbed **43**. Alternatively, either of both of the plates **198**, **199** could be further embedded in the heel footbed rather than exposed at either of the surfaces

200, 202.

(83) The plates **198, 199** may be relatively more rigid than the front midsole component **128A** (e.g., than a foam body **170** of the heel footbed **43** of the front midsole component **128A**). For example, the first plate **198** may have a first rigidity whereas the front midsole component **128A** (including the body **170** of the heel footbed **43**) may have a second rigidity less than the first rigidity.

Similarly, the second plate **199** may have a rigidity that is greater than the second rigidity of the front midsole component **128A** (including the body **170** of the heel footbed **43**). The more rigid plates **198, 199** may enable smoother transitioning between the access and use positions, allowing the heel footbed **43** to be more easily seated on the rear midsole component **128B** and within the rear upper portion **50B**.

(84) The more rigid plates **198, 199** may stiffen the heel footbed **43**, which may prevent twisting of the heel footbed **43** about the longitudinal axis of the heel footbed **43**, enabling it to move more easily past the rear upper portion **50B** and the clip **182**, and allowing the attached side tabs **64, 210** to move more easily into and out of the medial-side recess **214** and the lateral-side recess **212**, respectively, than would a heel footbed without either of the plates **198, 199** under foot loading on the heel footbed **43** or under a foot removal force on the cover **178** of the ledge **176** as discussed herein to move the sole structure **112** between the access position and the use position.

(85) As shown in FIG. **11**, a rear extent **204** of the first plate **198** is disposed rearward of a front extent **206** of the second plate **199** along a length of the heel footbed **43** such that the first plate **198** and the second plate **199** partially overlap (e.g., in the vertical direction of the sole structure **112**). Stated differently, a portion of the first plate **198** is stacked above a portion of the second plate **199** with a portion of the rear midsole component **128B** therebetween. The first plate **198** spans fore and aft over the entire groove **30** in the use position, and the front extent **206** of the second plate **199** is disposed partially over the groove **30** in the use position. Both the first plate **198** and the second plate **199** at least partially overlay the rear midsole component **128B** in the use position. A rear extent **208** of the second plate **199** is disposed forward of the medial-side tab **210** and the lateral-side tab **64** shown and discussed with respect to FIGS. **12-16**.

(86) Referring to FIG. **12**, the heel footbed **43** includes the lateral-side tab **64** protruding at the lateral-side periphery **66** of the heel footbed **43** and integrally formed with the lateral-side stiffening layer **68** as an integral portion thereof. The lateral-side stiffening layer **68** also extends partway under the heel footbed **43**. FIGS. **13** and **15** also show the lateral-side tab **64** and lateral-side stiffening layer **68**.

(87) FIG. **12** also shows that the heel footbed **43** includes a medial-side stiffening layer **209** secured at the medial-side periphery **69** of the heel footbed **43** and a medial-side tab **210** as an integral portion of the medial-side stiffening layer **209** and protruding outward at the medial-side periphery **69**. Like the lateral-side stiffening layer **68** and lateral-side tab **64**, the medial-side stiffening layer **209** and medial-side tab **210** are stiffer than the heel footbed **43**.

(88) FIG. **12** shows the inner surface **72** of the rear midsole component **128B** with a lateral-side recess **212** in a lateral side of the inner surface **72**, and a medial-side recess **214** in the medial side of the inner surface **72**. The recesses **212, 214** are best shown in FIG. **14** and are at the inner side walls **73A, 73B** of the rear midsole component **128B**. The lateral-side tab **64** is disposed in the lateral-side recess **212** when the sole structure **112** moves to the use position to secure the heel footbed **43** in the use position. Similarly, the medial-side tab **210** is disposed in the medial-side recess **214** when the sole structure **112** moves to the use position to further secure the heel footbed **43** in the use position. More specifically, the lateral-side tab **64** in the lateral-side recess **212** and the similar medial-side tab **210** in the medial-side recess **214** interlock the heel footbed **43** to the rear midsole component **28B** at both the medial side **22** and the lateral side **24** to help maintain the article of footwear **110** in the use position.

(89) FIG. **17** is a cross-sectional view of the sole structure **112** of the article of footwear **110** taken at lines III-III in FIG. **10** and shows the front midsole component **128A** and the insole **190**, with the

toe region outside component **142C** at the gap **46**.

(90) FIG. **18** is another cross-sectional view of the sole structure **112** of the article of footwear **110** taken at lines IV-IV in FIG. **10** and shows the bladder **196** in the recess **194** of the front midsole component **128A** with the insole **190** overlaying the bladder **196**.

(91) FIG. **19** is another cross-sectional view of the sole structure **112** of the article of footwear **110** taken at lines V-V in FIG. **10** at the peak **40** of the hinge **34** and showing a portion of the first plate **198**.

(92) FIGS. **20-25** show an alternative article of footwear **310** (see FIG. **25**) and sole structure **312**. Various components of the article of footwear **310** and sole structure **312** are alike in many aspects to the articles of footwear **10** and **110** and the sole structures **12** and **112**. Like components are indicated with like reference numbers.

(93) FIG. **20** is a top view of an external stiffening layer **268** for the heel footbed **43** of the front midsole component **128A** shown in FIG. **21** and is used in place of the separate stiffening layers **68** and **209** shown in FIG. **12**.

(94) The external stiffening layer **268** may be secured to the body **70** of the heel footbed **43** such as with adhesive, or may be coated on the body **70**, or otherwise applied to define a portion of the lateral-side periphery **66** of the heel footbed **43**, a portion of the medial-side periphery **69** of the heel footbed **43**, and a portion of the rear periphery of the heel footbed **43**. In one example, the external stiffening layer **268** is molded separately from the body **70** and is then adhered to the body **70**. In another example, foam used to form the body **70** may be processed such as by temperature-controlled curing so that the external stiffening layer **268** is an integral external skin of the body **70** that is more dense than a remaining internal portion of the body **70** that it covers.

(95) The external stiffening layer **268** has an integral medial-side tab **311** and an integral lateral-side tab **364**. The integral medial-side tab **311** and the integral lateral-side tab **364** are longer than the side tabs **210** and **64** of the sole structure **12** (e.g., extend further in the longitudinal direction of the article of footwear **310** of FIG. **25**). The increased length may better maintain the heel footbed **43** interlocked with the rear midsole component **128B** in the use position.

(96) The body **70** may be relatively less hard than the external stiffening layer **268** and the integral lateral-side tab **64**. For example, the body **70** may have a first hardness and the external stiffening layer **268**, the integral medial-side tab **311**, and the integral lateral-side tab **364** may have a second hardness greater than the first hardness. For example, the body **70** may be elastomeric foam, as discussed, and the external stiffening layer **268**, the integral medial-side tab **311**, and the integral lateral-side tab **364** may be a semi-rigid or rigid plastic (such as a thermoplastic), a composite, nylon, a polyether block amide such as PEBAX® available from Arkema, Inc. in King of Prussia, Pennsylvania USA, a fiberglass reinforced polyamide, a rigid thermoplastic polyurethane (with or without glass fiber).

(97) The external stiffening layer **268** defines a through-hole **269** positioned to be aligned with the bottom recess **129** in the rear midsole component **128B** when in the use position in order to maintain resilient heel cushioning. The external stiffening layer **268** also defines an integral and upwardly-protruding ledge **271** having an upper surface **273** configured to interface with a lower surface **284** of the integral clip **282** of the peripheral support **283** for the rear midsole component **128B** of FIG. **23**. This is best shown in the cross-sectional view of FIG. **25**. The forward and downward slope of the integral clip **282** helps the ledge **271** to slide over the flexible integral clip **282** when the sole structure moves to the use position, and the interfacing surfaces **273**, **284** help to enable the integral clip **282** to maintain the ledge **271** (and the external stiffening layer **268** and rear midsole component **128B** connected thereto) below the clip **282** once the rear midsole component **128B** moves past the integral clip **282** during foot entry.

(98) The peripheral support **283** may also be referred to as a wall support, an inner wall support, or a peripheral wall support, and is stiffer than the rear midsole component **128B**. For example, as described, the rear midsole component **128B** may be any of the materials described with respect to

the rear midsole component **28B**, such as foam, while the peripheral support **283** may be PEBAX® or any of the materials described with respect to the external stiffening layer **268**.

(99) The peripheral support **283** extends around the inner surface **72** from the medial side **22** at the medial inner side wall **73A** to the lateral side **24** at the lateral inner side wall **73B**, and around the rear of the inner surface **72** of the rear midsole component **128B**. The peripheral support **283** extends downward at the inner surface **72** at the side walls **73A**, **73B** and has an edge **285** that is disposed adjacent to the recesses **212**, **214** to further define the recesses **212**, **214**. As shown, the edge **285** is a bottom edge or lower edge of the peripheral support **283** at the recesses **212**, **214**, and establishes a top boundary of the recesses **212**, **214** in which the tabs **364**, **311** may be disposed. The tabs **364**, **311** are complementary interlocking features with the recesses **212**, **214** and the peripheral support **283**.

(100) Accordingly, the peripheral support **283** serves to limit the ability of the side walls **73A**, **73B** of the rear midsole component **128B** (shown in FIG. **14**) to flex outwardly thus reducing the possibility of the side tabs **364** and **311** coming out of the recesses **212**, **214**. The peripheral support **283** is shaped to nest against and be secured to the side walls **73A**, **73B** at the inner surface **72** of the rear midsole component **128B** with a lower medial edge **285** disposed adjacent to the medial-side recess **214** to further define the medial-side recess **214** and a lower lateral edge **287** disposed adjacent to the lateral-side recess **212** to further define the lateral-side recess **212**. The tabs **364**, **311** are thus disposed in the respective recesses **212**, **214** under the edges **285**, **287** of the peripheral support **283** when the sole structure **312** moves to the use position to secure the heel footbed **43** in the use position.

(101) The peripheral support **283** extends to the forward edges **287**, **289** of the side walls **73A**, **73B** of the rear midsole component **128B** and follows the slope of the forward edges **287**, **289**.

Additionally, the peripheral support **283** includes integral feet **293**, **295** that interface with and may be fixed to the foot-facing portion **45** of the inner surface **72** of the rear midsole component **128B**. By following the forward edges **287**, **289** of the side walls **73A**, **73B** and further extending along the foot-facing portion **45** of the inner surface **72**, the peripheral support **283** reduces any twisting or bowing of the rear midsole component. The peripheral support **283** also has an integral cover **378** similar to the cover **178** on which the wearer's opposite foot can press downwards at the external ledge **176** of the rear midsole component **128B** to enable the heel footbed **43** and external stiffening layer **268** to move past the clip **282** when returning to the access position.

(102) FIG. **24** is a cross-sectional view of the heel footbed **43** and the external stiffening layer **268** of FIGS. **20-22** taken at lines VI-VI in FIG. **21** when the side tabs **364**, **311** are disposed in recesses **212**, **214** of the rear midsole component **128B** below the edges **285**, **287** of the peripheral support **283** of FIG. **23**.

(103) FIG. **23** also shows a transversely-extending resilient band **302** that is secured at the side walls **73A**, **73B** slightly spaced apart from (e.g., spaced above) the inner surface **72** (e.g., above the foot-facing portion **45** of the inner surface **72**) of the rear midsole component **128B**. Stated differently, when the rear midsole component **128B** is not supporting a foot, the resilient band **302** is spaced above and extends over the foot-facing portion **45** with a gap therebetween (e.g., the resilient band **302** is not touching and not laying on the foot-facing portion **45**). The resilient band **302** is sufficiently taut in the state shown in FIG. **23** that it can serve as a resting support that maintains the heel footbed **43** in the access position, like that shown in FIG. **3**, for example. Stated differently, the bottom of the heel footbed **43** can rest against and be supported by the resilient band **302** when the sole structure **312** is in the access position.

(104) During foot entry, when the sole structure **312** moves to the use position, the resilient band **302** resiliently stretches and is moved against the foot-facing portion **45** of the inner surface **72** of the rear midsole component **128B** by the heel footbed **43**, as shown in FIG. **25**. The interlocking of the tabs **364**, **311** in the recesses **212**, **214**, respectively, as well as the integral clip **282** over the ledge **271** maintains the rear midsole component **128B** in the use position of FIG. **25**. The bias of

the resilient band **302** to the position of FIG. **23** does not overcome these features and does not return the sole structure **312** to the access position.

(105) FIG. **25** is a cross-sectional view of the article of footwear **310** including the divided footwear upper **14** with the front upper portion **50A** and rear upper portion **50B** shown in phantom. The sole structure **312** includes the front midsole component **128A** with the heel footbed **43** and external stiffening layer **268** of FIG. **21**, and the rear midsole component **128B** and peripheral support **283** of FIG. **23**. It is clear in the close-up view shown at **25A** in FIG. **25** that the integral clip **282** has a slightly downward slope in a forward direction at its upper surface **275** that interfaces with the external stiffening layer **268** as the sole structure **312** moves to the use position. This causes sliding of the external stiffening layer **268** past the clip **282** to the use position. The lower surface **284** of the clip **282** is configured to interface with the upper surface **273** of the ledge **271**. For example, they may each have relatively flat surfaces or sloped surfaces configured to interface. The interfacing surfaces **273**, **284** help maintain the external stiffening layer **268** and the heel footbed **43** below the clip **282** in the use position.

(106) Accordingly, the articles of footwear **10**, **110**, and **310** disclosed herein provide easy access for foot insertion and foot removal without the use of any band or other biasing member to maintain the sole structure **12**, **112** in either the use position or the access position. The article of footwear **310** utilizes the transversely-extending resilient band **302** to help support the heel footbed **43** in the access position, but includes no band or other biasing member that extends between the front upper portion **50A** and the rear upper portion **50B**, or between the front midsole component **128A** and the rear midsole component **128B**, or between the front upper portion **50A** and the rear midsole component **128B**, or between the rear upper portion **50B** and the front midsole component **128A** to move the sole structure **312** in the access position or in the use position.

(107) The following Clauses provide example configurations of articles of footwear disclosed herein.

(108) Clause 1. An article of footwear comprising: a sole structure including: a front midsole component and a separate rear midsole component, the front midsole component and the rear midsole component together defining a groove at a lower side of the sole structure between the front midsole component and the rear midsole component; and a hinge disposed in the groove and connecting the front midsole component to the rear midsole component; wherein: the front midsole component and the rear midsole component are pivotable relative to one another at the groove between a use position and an access position with the groove relatively open in the use position and relatively closed in the access position; the front midsole component includes a heel footbed that extends over the groove and overlays the rear midsole component in the use position, and is spaced apart from the rear midsole component in the access position; and the rear midsole component includes an inner surface with a recess in a side of the inner surface; the sole structure further including a tab protruding at a side periphery of the heel footbed; and wherein the tab is disposed in the recess when the sole structure moves to the use position to secure the heel footbed in the use position.

(109) Clause 2. The article of footwear of clause 1, wherein: the sole structure further comprises a stiffening layer secured at the side periphery of the heel footbed; and the stiffening layer is stiffer than the heel footbed and includes the tab.

(110) Clause 3. The article of footwear of any of clauses 1-2, wherein: the side of the inner surface of the rear midsole component is a lateral side; the recess is a lateral-side recess; the side periphery of the heel footbed is a lateral-side periphery; and the tab is a lateral-side tab.

(111) Clause 4. The article of footwear of clause 3, wherein: the rear midsole component further includes a medial side recess along a medial side of the inner surface; the heel footbed includes a medial side tab protruding at a medial side periphery of the heel footbed; and the medial side tab is disposed in the medial side recess when the sole structure moves to the use position to further secure the heel footbed in the use position.

(112) Clause 5. The article of footwear of any of clauses 1-4, wherein: the side of the inner surface of the rear midsole component is a medial side; the recess is a medial side recess; the side periphery of the heel footbed is a medial side periphery; and the tab is a medial side tab.

(113) Clause 6. The article of footwear of any of clauses 1-5, wherein: a clip projects forward from the inner surface of the rear midsole component; the clip overlays a rear extent of the heel footbed when the sole structure is in the use position; and the clip flexibly interfaces with the rear extent of the heel footbed when the sole structure moves from the access position to the use position and from the use position to the access position.

(114) Clause 7. The article of footwear of clause 6, wherein a rear extent of the rear midsole component defines an external ledge positioned rearward of the clip such that depressing the external ledge moves the clip away from the rear extent of the heel footbed.

(115) Clause 8. The article of footwear of clause 7, further comprising: a cover disposed on the external ledge; wherein the cover is integral with the clip.

(116) Clause 9. The article of footwear of any of clauses 1-8, the sole structure further comprising: a first plate disposed on or in the heel footbed and extending over the groove in the use position; and a second plate disposed on or in the heel footbed, the second plate disposed nearer to a bottom surface of the heel footbed than the first plate, and the first plate disposed nearer to a top surface of the heel footbed than the second plate.

(117) Clause 10. The article of footwear of clause 9, wherein a rear extent of the first plate is disposed rearward of a front extent of the second plate along a length of the heel footbed such that the first plate and the second plate partially overlap.

(118) Clause 11. The article of footwear of clause 10, wherein the first plate is disposed at the top surface of the heel footbed and the second plate is disposed at the bottom surface of the heel footbed.

(119) Clause 12. The article of footwear of any of clauses 10-11, wherein the front extent of the second plate is disposed partially over the groove in the use position.

(120) Clause 13. The article of footwear of any of clauses 10-12, wherein both the first plate and the second plate at least partially overlay the rear midsole component in the use position.

(121) Clause 14. The article of footwear of any of clauses 10-13, wherein a rear extent of the second plate is disposed forward of the tab.

(122) Clause 15. The article of footwear of any of clauses 1-14, wherein: the front midsole component includes a first wall defining a front of the groove; the rear midsole component includes a second wall defining a rear of the groove; and the hinge lines the first wall and the second wall and defines a peak therebetween, the hinge flexing at the peak when the sole structure moves between the use position and the access position.

(123) Clause 16. The article of footwear of clause 15, wherein: the hinge includes a forward leg extending forward from the first wall; and the hinge includes a rear leg extending rearward from the second wall.

(124) Clause 17. The article of footwear of clause 16, wherein the sole structure further includes an outsole secured to a bottom surface of the front midsole component and to a bottom surface of the rear midsole component.

(125) Clause 18. The article of footwear of clause 17, wherein the outsole includes: a front outsole component secured to the bottom surface of the front midsole component and to the forward leg of the hinge; and a rear outsole component discrete and separate from the front outsole component; wherein the rear outsole component is secured to the bottom surface of the rear midsole component and to the rear leg of the hinge.

(126) Clause 19. The article of footwear of any of clauses 1-18, further comprising: a divided footwear upper secured to the sole structure to define a foot-receiving cavity; wherein the divided footwear upper includes a front upper portion secured to the front midsole component, and a separate rear upper portion secured to the rear midsole component; and wherein the sole structure is

characterized by an absence of a biasing member extending between the front upper portion and the rear upper portion, and the absence of a biasing member extending between the front midsole component and the rear midsole component, and the absence of a biasing member extending between the front upper portion and the rear midsole component, and the absence of a biasing member extending between the rear upper portion and the front midsole component.

(127) Clause 20. The article of footwear of clause 19, wherein: the rear upper portion includes at least a portion of a heel collar; and the heel collar is configured to support the heel footbed in the access position and resiliently deform to permit the heel footbed to move past the heel collar to the use position.

(128) Clause 21. The article of footwear of any of clauses 1-20, wherein: the sole structure further includes an outsole secured a bottom surface of the front midsole component and to a bottom surface of the rear midsole component; and the outsole is characterized by at least a predetermined coefficient of friction to maintain the sole structure in the access position.

(129) Clause 22. An article of footwear comprising: a sole structure including: a front midsole component and a separate rear midsole component, the front midsole component and the rear midsole component together defining a groove at a lower side of the sole structure between the front midsole component and the rear midsole component; and a hinge disposed in the groove and connecting the front midsole component to the rear midsole component; wherein the front midsole component and the rear midsole component are pivotable relative to one another at the groove between a use position and an access position with the groove relatively open in the use position and relatively closed in the access position; and wherein the article of footwear is characterized by an absence of a biasing member configured to maintain the sole structure in the use position or in the access position.

(130) Clause 23. The article of footwear of clause 22, further comprising: a divided footwear upper secured to the sole structure to define a foot-receiving cavity, the divided footwear upper including a front upper portion secured to the front midsole component, and a separate rear upper portion secured to the rear midsole component; wherein the article of footwear is characterized by an absence of a biasing member extending between the front upper portion and the rear upper portion, and the absence of a biasing member extending between the front midsole component and the rear midsole component, and the absence of a biasing member extending between the front upper portion and the rear midsole component, and the absence of a biasing member extending between the rear upper portion and the front midsole component.

(131) Clause 24. The article of footwear of any of clauses 22-23, the sole structure further comprising: an outsole secured a bottom surface of the front midsole component and to a bottom surface of the rear midsole component; wherein the outsole is characterized by at least a predetermined coefficient of friction to maintain the sole structure in the access position.

(132) Clause 25. The article of footwear of any of clauses 22-24, further comprising: a divided footwear upper secured to the sole structure to define a foot-receiving cavity, the divided footwear upper including a front upper portion secured to the front midsole component, and a separate rear upper portion secured to the rear midsole component; wherein: the rear upper portion includes at least a portion of a heel collar; the front midsole component includes a heel footbed that extends over the groove and overlays the rear midsole component in the use position, and is spaced apart from the rear midsole component in the access position; and the heel collar is configured to support the heel footbed in the access position and resiliently deform to permit the heel footbed to move past the heel collar to the use position.

(133) Clause 26. An article of footwear comprising: a sole structure including: a front midsole component and a separate rear midsole component, the front midsole component and the rear midsole component together defining a groove at a lower side of the sole structure between the front midsole component and the rear midsole component; and a hinge disposed in the groove and connecting the front midsole component to the rear midsole component; wherein: the front midsole

component and the rear midsole component are pivotable relative to one another at the groove between a use position and an access position with the groove relatively open in the use position and relatively closed in the access position; the front midsole component includes a heel footbed that extends over the groove and overlays the rear midsole component in the use position, and is spaced apart from the rear midsole component in the access position; the rear midsole component includes an inner surface; and a side of the heel footbed and the inner surface of the rear midsole component include complementary interlocking features that secure the heel footbed in the use position.

(134) An “article of footwear”, a “footwear article of manufacture”, and “footwear” may be considered to be both a machine and a manufacture. Assembled, ready to wear footwear articles (e.g., shoes, sandals, boots, etc.), as well as discrete components of footwear articles (such as a midsole, an outsole, an upper component, etc.) prior to final assembly into ready to wear footwear articles, are considered and alternatively referred to herein in either the singular or plural as “article(s) of footwear”.

(135) “A”, “an”, “the”, “at least one”, and “one or more” are used interchangeably to indicate that at least one of the items is present. A plurality of such items may be present unless the context clearly indicates otherwise. All numerical values of parameters (e.g., of quantities or conditions) in this specification, unless otherwise indicated expressly or clearly in view of the context, including the appended claims, are to be understood as being modified in all instances by the term “about” whether or not “about” actually appears before the numerical value. “About” indicates that the stated numerical value allows some slight imprecision (with some approach to exactness in the value; approximately or reasonably close to the value; nearly). If the imprecision provided by “about” is not otherwise understood in the art with this ordinary meaning, then “about” as used herein indicates at least variations that may arise from ordinary methods of measuring and using such parameters. In addition, a disclosure of a range is to be understood as specifically disclosing all values and further divided ranges within the range.

(136) The terms “comprising”, “including”, and “having” are inclusive and therefore specify the presence of stated features, steps, operations, elements, or components, but do not preclude the presence or addition of one or more other features, steps, operations, elements, or components. Orders of steps, processes, and operations may be altered when possible, and additional or alternative steps may be employed. As used in this specification, the term “or” includes any one and all combinations of the associated listed items. The term “any of” is understood to include any possible combination of referenced items, including “any one of” the referenced items. The term “any of” is understood to include any possible combination of referenced claims of the appended claims, including “any one of” the referenced claims.

(137) For consistency and convenience, directional adjectives may be employed throughout this detailed description corresponding to the illustrated embodiments. Those having ordinary skill in the art will recognize that terms such as “above”, “below”, “upward”, “downward”, “top”, “bottom”, etc., may be used descriptively relative to the figures, without representing limitations on the scope of the invention, as defined by the claims.

(138) The term “longitudinal” particularly refers to a direction extending a length of a component. For example, a longitudinal direction of a shoe extends between a forefoot region and a heel region of the shoe. The term “forward” or “anterior” is used to particularly refer to the general direction from a heel region toward a forefoot region, and the term “rearward” or “posterior” is used to particularly refer to the opposite direction, i.e., the direction from the forefoot region toward the heel region. In some cases, a component may be identified with a longitudinal axis as well as a forward and rearward longitudinal direction along that axis. The longitudinal direction or axis may also be referred to as an anterior-posterior direction or axis.

(139) The term “transverse” particularly refers to a direction extending a width of a component. For example, a transverse direction of a shoe extends between a lateral side and a medial side of the

shoe. The transverse direction or axis may also be referred to as a lateral direction or axis or a mediolateral direction or axis.

(140) The term “vertical” particularly refers to a direction generally perpendicular to both the lateral and longitudinal directions. For example, in cases where an outsole is planted flat on a ground surface, the vertical direction may extend from the ground surface upward. It will be understood that each of these directional adjectives may be applied to individual components of a sole. The term “upward” or “upwards” particularly refers to the vertical direction pointing towards a top of the component, which may include an instep, a fastening region and/or a throat of an upper. The term “downward” or “downwards” particularly refers to the vertical direction pointing opposite the upwards direction, toward the bottom of a component and may generally point towards the bottom of a sole structure of an article of footwear.

(141) The “interior” of an article of footwear, such as a shoe, particularly refers to portions at the space that is occupied by a wearer's foot when the shoe is worn. The “inner side” of a component particularly refers to the side or surface of the component that is (or will be) oriented toward the interior of the component or article of footwear in an assembled article of footwear. The “outer side” or “exterior” of a component particularly refers to the side or surface of the component that is (or will be) oriented away from the interior of the shoe in an assembled shoe. In some cases, other components may be between the inner side of a component and the interior in the assembled article of footwear. Similarly, other components may be between an outer side of a component and the space external to the assembled article of footwear. Further, the terms “inward” and “inwardly” particularly refer to the direction toward the interior of the component or article of footwear, such as a shoe, and the terms “outward” and “outwardly” particularly refer to the direction toward the exterior of the component or article of footwear, such as the shoe. In addition, the term “proximal” particularly refers to a direction that is nearer a center of a footwear component, or is closer toward a foot when the foot is inserted in the article of footwear as it is worn by a user. Likewise, the term “distal” particularly refers to a relative position that is further away from a center of the footwear component or is further from a foot when the foot is inserted in the article of footwear as it is worn by a user. Thus, the terms proximal and distal may be understood to provide generally opposing terms to describe relative spatial positions.

(142) While various embodiments have been described, the description is intended to be exemplary, rather than limiting and it will be apparent to those of ordinary skill in the art that many more embodiments and implementations are possible that are within the scope of the embodiments. Any feature of any embodiment may be used in combination with or substituted for any other feature or element in any other embodiment unless specifically restricted. Accordingly, the embodiments are not to be restricted except in light of the attached claims and their equivalents. Also, various modifications and changes may be made within the scope of the attached claims.

(143) While several modes for carrying out the many aspects of the present teachings have been described in detail, those familiar with the art to which these teachings relate will recognize various alternative aspects for practicing the present teachings that are within the scope of the appended claims. It is intended that all matter contained in the above description or shown in the accompanying drawings shall be interpreted as illustrative and exemplary of the entire range of alternative embodiments that an ordinarily skilled artisan would recognize as implied by, structurally and/or functionally equivalent to, or otherwise rendered obvious based upon the included content, and not as limited solely to those explicitly depicted and/or described embodiments.

Claims

1. An article of footwear comprising: a sole structure including: a front midsole component and a separate rear midsole component, the front midsole component and the rear midsole component

together defining a groove at a lower side of the sole structure between the front midsole component and the rear midsole component; a divided footwear upper secured to the sole structure to define a foot-receiving cavity; and a hinge disposed in the groove and connecting the front midsole component to the rear midsole component; wherein: the divided footwear upper includes a front upper portion secured to the front midsole component, and a separate rear upper portion secured to the rear midsole component; the front midsole component and the rear midsole component are pivotable relative to one another at the groove between a use position and an access position with the groove relatively open in the use position and relatively closed in the access position; the front midsole component includes a heel footbed that extends over the groove and overlays the rear midsole component in the use position, and is spaced apart from the rear midsole component in the access position; the rear midsole component includes an inner surface and at least partially defines a recess at the inner surface; the sole structure further including a tab protruding at a side periphery of the heel footbed; wherein the tab is disposed in the recess when the sole structure moves to the use position to secure the heel footbed in the use position; and wherein the sole structure is characterized by an absence of a biasing member extending between and connecting the front upper portion and the rear upper portion, and the absence of a biasing member extending between and connecting the front midsole component and the rear midsole component, and the absence of a biasing member extending between and connecting the front upper portion and the rear midsole component, and the absence of a biasing member extending between and connecting the rear upper portion and the front midsole component.

2. The article of footwear of claim 1, wherein: the sole structure further comprises a stiffening layer secured at the side periphery of the heel footbed; and the stiffening layer is stiffer than the heel footbed and includes the tab.

3. The article of footwear of claim 1, wherein: the recess is a lateral-side recess at a lateral side of the inner surface, the side periphery of the heel footbed is a lateral-side periphery, and the tab is a lateral-side tab; the rear midsole component at least partially defines a medial-side recess at a medial side of the inner surface; the sole structure further includes a medial-side tab protruding at a medial-side periphery of the heel footbed; and wherein the medial-side tab is disposed in the medial-side recess when the sole structure moves to the use position to further secure the heel footbed in the use position.

4. The article of footwear of claim 3, wherein: the sole structure further comprises a stiffening layer secured at the side periphery of the heel footbed; and the lateral-side tab and the medial-side tab are integral with the stiffening layer.

5. The article of footwear of claim 1, further comprising: a peripheral support secured to the rear midsole component and having an edge disposed adjacent to the recess to further define the recess; wherein the peripheral support is stiffer than the rear midsole component; and wherein the tab is disposed in the recess under the edge of the peripheral support when the sole structure moves to the use position to secure the heel footbed in the use position.

6. The article of footwear of claim 5, wherein: the peripheral support includes an integral clip that projects forward from the inner surface of the rear midsole component; the clip overlays a rear extent of the heel footbed when the sole structure is in the use position; and the clip flexibly interfaces with the heel footbed when the sole structure moves from the access position to the use position and from the use position to the access position.

7. The article of footwear of claim 1, wherein: a clip projects forward from the inner surface of the rear midsole component; and the clip overlays a rear extent of the heel footbed when the sole structure is in the use position.

8. The article of footwear of claim 7, wherein a rear extent of the rear midsole component defines an external ledge positioned rearward of the clip such that depressing the external ledge moves the clip away from the rear extent of the heel footbed.

9. The article of footwear of claim 8, further comprising: a cover disposed on the external ledge;

and wherein the cover is integral with the clip.

10. The article of footwear of claim 1, the sole structure further comprising: a first plate disposed on or in the heel footbed and extending over the groove in the use position; and a second plate disposed on or in the heel footbed, the second plate disposed nearer to a bottom surface of the heel footbed than the first plate, and the first plate disposed nearer to a top surface of the heel footbed than the second plate.

11. The article of footwear of claim 10, wherein a rear extent of the first plate is disposed rearward of a front extent of the second plate along a length of the heel footbed such that the first plate and the second plate partially overlap.

12. The article of footwear of claim 11, wherein the first plate is disposed at the top surface of the heel footbed and the second plate is disposed at the bottom surface of the heel footbed.

13. The article of footwear of claim 11, wherein the front extent of the second plate is disposed partially over the groove in the use position.

14. The article of footwear of claim 11, wherein both the first plate and the second plate at least partially overlay the rear midsole component in the use position.

15. The article of footwear of claim 11, wherein a rear extent of the second plate is disposed forward of the tab.

16. The article of footwear of claim 1, further comprising: a resilient band suspended over and extending transversely across a portion of the inner surface of the rear midsole component; wherein, in the access position, the resilient band is spaced apart from the portion of the inner surface of the rear midsole component and the heel footbed rests on the resilient band; and wherein, in the use position, the resilient band resiliently stretches under load and the heel footbed rests on the inner surface of the rear midsole component.

17. The article of footwear of claim 1, wherein: the front midsole component includes a first wall defining a front of the groove; the rear midsole component includes a second wall defining a rear of the groove; and the hinge lines the first wall and the second wall and defines a peak therebetween, the hinge flexing at the peak when the sole structure moves between the use position and the access position.

18. An article of footwear comprising: a sole structure including: a front midsole component and a separate rear midsole component, the front midsole component and the rear midsole component together defining a groove at a lower side of the sole structure between the front midsole component and the rear midsole component; and a hinge disposed in the groove and connecting the front midsole component to the rear midsole component; and a resilient band suspended over and extending transversely across a portion of an inner surface of the rear midsole component; wherein: the front midsole component and the rear midsole component are pivotable relative to one another at the groove between a use position and an access position with the groove relatively open in the use position and relatively closed in the access position; the front midsole component includes a heel footbed that extends over the groove and overlays the rear midsole component in the use position, and is spaced apart from the rear midsole component in the access position; the rear midsole component includes an inner surface; a side of the heel footbed and the inner surface of the rear midsole component include complementary interlocking features that secure the heel footbed in the use position; in the access position, the resilient band is spaced apart from the portion of the inner surface of the rear midsole component and the heel footbed rests on the resilient band; and in the use position, the resilient band stretches under load and the heel footbed further rests on the inner surface of the rear midsole component.

19. An article of footwear comprising: a sole structure including: a front midsole component and a rear midsole component, the front midsole component and the rear midsole component together defining a groove at a lower side of the sole structure between the front midsole component and the rear midsole component; wherein the front midsole component and the rear midsole component are pivotable relative to one another at the groove between a use position and an access position with

the groove relatively open in the use position and relatively closed in the access position; wherein the front midsole component includes a heel footbed that extends over the groove and overlays the rear midsole component in the use position, and is spaced apart from the rear midsole component in the access position; wherein the rear midsole component includes an inner surface and at least partially defines a recess at the inner surface; a tab protruding at a periphery of the heel footbed; a peripheral support secured to the rear midsole component and having an edge disposed adjacent to the recess to further define the recess, the peripheral support including an integral clip that projects forward from the inner surface of the rear midsole component, and the peripheral support further including an integral cover disposed on an external ledge of a rear extent of the rear midsole component and positioned rearward of the clip; wherein the clip overlays a rear extent of the heel footbed when the sole structure is in the use position; and wherein the clip flexibly interfaces with the heel footbed when the sole structure moves from the use position to the access position when the external ledge is depressed at the cover to move the clip away from the rear extent of the heel footbed.

20. The article of footwear of claim 19, wherein the peripheral support includes integral feet that interface with a foot-facing portion of the inner surface of the rear midsole component.
